

How To Quote

Citation forms the basis for writing academic texts and is indispensable for writing a term paper. By citing sources, you can identify the ideas of other authors that have been used to support your own argumentation. This happens regardless of whether you use the exact words or just a thought of another person. Quoting makes argumentations in academic papers more transparent and comprehensible by avoiding plagiarism - arguments/text passages of other authors, which are not marked as such.

It is also important to integrate quotations meaningfully into the text and to only use quotations whose meaning is fully understood. You can either use direct quotations, in which the exact wording of an author is written in double quotation marks, or indirect quotations, in which the same thought is expressed in your own words. In the case of longer direct quotations, the text passage can be indented to make it recognizable as a citation. A stringing together of quotations is to be avoided in principle, rather they should be syntactically incorporated into the own argumentation structure. Furthermore, secondary quotations should be avoided. Secondary quotations are quotations, which are already quoted in another source and are not read by oneself. If you should use a secondary citation anyway, because for example the primary literature is not available, the citation has to be declared as such.

Citation styles

One difficulty in citing is the large selection of different citation methods. Lecturers often specify the style in which they want quotes to be cited, sometimes students can decide for themselves which style they want to use. It is important that you use the same style consistently! Roughly speaking, a distinction is made between two styles:

The **Harvard** way of citing is to quote in the text, i.e. short details about the author and year of publication are given behind the respective sentence. This method of citation is currently gaining popularity and scores particularly well because the focus remains on the text while reading.

Example: The tutor expresses his opinion as follows: "Quoting is easier than it seems at first!" (Müller 2020: 12).

However, it is also possible to quote in footnotes, in which the text refers to the corresponding footnote by a number. This style makes the text appear neat and tidy and is used primarily in humanities. In contrast to the Harvard citation style, the footnotes provide a complete indication of the source.

Example: The tutor expresses his view as follows: "Quoting is easier than it seems at first!" ¹

¹Max, Müller, Citation. Lüneburg: Uni-Verlag 2020, p.12.

Bibliography

A bibliography must be attached at the end of the scientific work. The bibliography provides more detailed information on the individual sources and is arranged alphabetically. The form of the bibliography is based on the citation style.

Harvard Example: Müller, Max (2020), Citation, 2nd ed., Lüneburg.

Footnotes Example: Max, Müller, citation. Lüneburg: Uni-Verlag 2020.

Abbreviations

In scientific papers, abbreviations are used for citation, for example to indicate errors.

Here you can find a list of all important and common abbreviations. 

Citation programs

Citation programs such as Zotero or Citavi make citing easier by allowing you to enter only the individual sources and the program formats them according to the chosen citation style. In the end, of course, the bibliography should also be cross-checked. In addition, you can also enter footnotes in writing programs like Word with the help of appropriate functions. The Leuphana writing center also offers training for selected programs and here you can find self-study materials. 